

ART & CULTURE



PUPPETRY & MARTIAL ARTS

MODULE - 1

PUPPETRY IN INDIA

INTRODUCTION



- 1 Puppetry is one of the ancient forms of entertainment.
- 2 The suggestive element of a puppet being **controlled by a master** makes it a captivating experience, while the **low cost of animation and production** of a performance makes it popular among freelance artists.
- 3 The form gives **unrestricted freedom** to the artist in form, design, colour and movements and makes it one of the **most ingenious inventions** of mankind.

INDIAN PUPPETRY

INDIAN ORIGINS

- 1 Puppetry has long been of interest in India, both for entertainment and educational purposes.
- 2 The excavation sites at Harappa and Mohenjo-Daro have yielded puppets with sockets attached to them, which suggest the presence of puppetry as an art form.
- 3 Some references of marionette theatre have been found in the period around 500 B.C. However, the oldest written reference to puppetry is found in the Tamil classic Silappadikaaram, written around 1st and 2nd century B.C.
- 4 Apart from the art form, puppetry has been of philosophical importance in the Indian culture.
- 5 In the Bhagwata, God has been described as a puppeteer, controlling the universe with the three strings – Satta, Raja and Tama.
- 6 Similarly, in the Indian theatre, the narrator was called Sutradhar, or the 'holder of strings'.

INDIAN ORIGINS



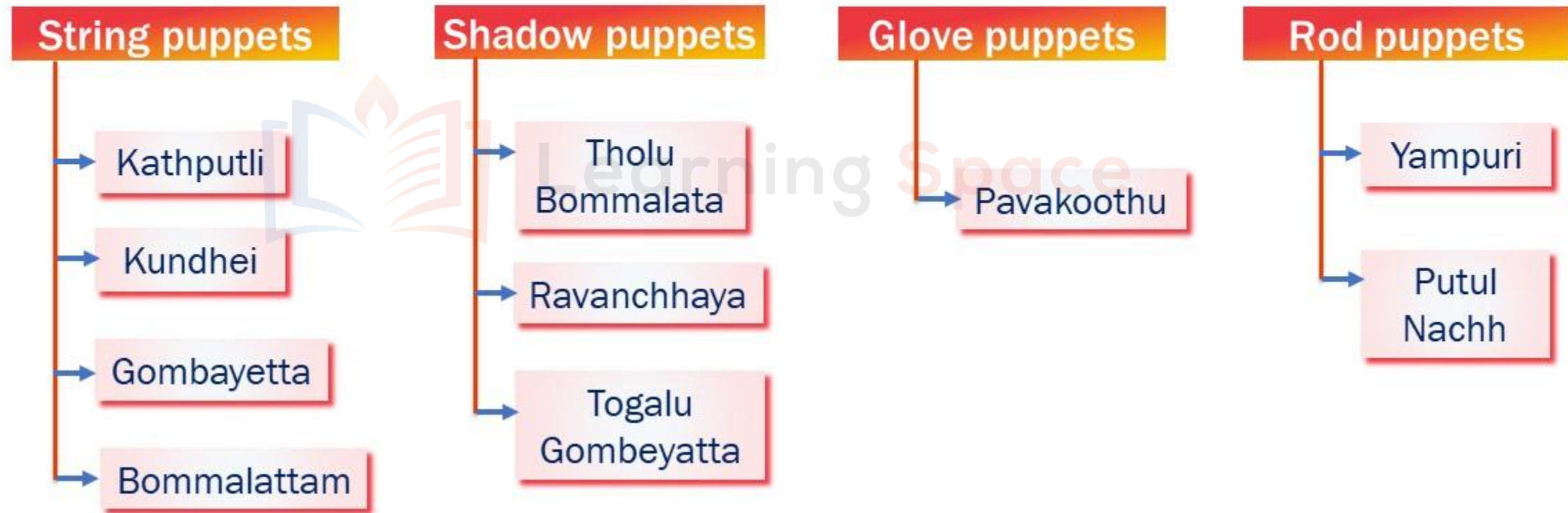
However, the lack of a devoted audience and financial security has led to a steady decline of this art form in the modern times.

- 7 A large variety of puppetry traditions have developed in various parts across India, **each with their own distinct form of puppets.**
- 8 Stories adapted from mythology, folk lore and local legends were adopted in these puppetry forms.
- 9 Puppetry has **imbibed elements** of painting, sculpture, music, dance and drama and created a **unique avenue of artistic expression.**

INDIAN PUPPETRY

INDIAN ORIGINS

Puppetry in India can be broadly classified into four categories. A brief outline of each with some prominent examples is given as follows:



INDIAN PUPPETRY

STRING PUPPETS

String puppets or marionettes have a prominent presence in the Indian cultural traditions. The features of string puppets are:



- 1 The puppets are generally 8-9 inch miniature figures **chiselled** out of **wood**.

- 2 **Oil colour** is used to paint the wood with skin colour and add other facial features such as eyes, lips, nose, etc.
- 3 Small wooden pipes are created with the body to form the limbs. The body is then covered with **colourful miniature dress and stitched**.
- 4 **Miniature jewellerys** and other accessories are attached to give a **realistic feel**.
- 5 **Strings** are attached to small holes in the hands, head and back of the body which are then **controlled by the puppeteer**.

POPULAR EXAMPLES OF STRING PUPPETRY IN INDIA

1

KATHPUTLI



- 5 Oval faces, large eyes, arched eyebrows and large lips are some of the distinct facial features of these string puppets.

- 1 The traditional string puppets of the Rajasthan area are known as Kathputli, which derives its name from 'Kath' meaning wood and 'putli' meaning doll.

- 2 The puppets are covered in traditionally bright Rajasthani dress.

- 3 The show is accompanied by a dramatic folk music.

- 4 A unique feature of the puppets is the absence of legs. The strings are attached to the finger of the puppeteer.

POPULAR EXAMPLES OF STRING PUPPETRY IN INDIA

1

KATHPUTLI



POPULAR EXAMPLES OF STRING
PUPPETRY IN INDIA

2

KUNDHEI



- 6 The costumes of Kundhei resemble those worn by actors of the **Jatra** traditional theatre.

- 1 The string puppets of Odisha are known as Kundhei.
- 2 They are **made of light wood** and are dressed in **long skirts**.
- 3 The puppets have **more joints**, thus giving the puppeteer **more flexibility**.
- 4 The strings are attached to a **triangular prop**.
- 5 There is a **marked influence of Odissi dance** on Kundhei puppet show.

POPULAR EXAMPLES OF STRING
PUPPETRY IN INDIA

3

GOMBAYETTA



- 1 It is the traditional puppet show of **Karnataka**.

- 2 They are styled and designed on the various characters of the **Yakshagana theatres**.
- 3 They are **highly stylized** and have joints at the legs, shoulders, elbows, hips and knees.
- 4 These puppets are manipulated by **five to seven strings tied to a prop**.
- 5 A unique feature of this puppetry is that **more than one puppeteer** is used to manipulate the puppets.

POPULAR EXAMPLES OF STRING
PUPPETRY IN INDIA

4

BOMMALATTAM



- 1 Bommalattam is the puppetry indigenous to the region of **Tamil Nadu**.

- 2 It combines features of **rod and string puppetry**.

- 3 The strings are attached to **an iron ring** which is worn by the puppeteer on his head or **some just hold the strings on hands**.

- 4 The Bommalattam puppets are the **largest and heaviest marionettes** found in India, with some of them as large as 4.5 ft in height and 10 kg in weight.

- 5 The Bommalattam theatre has four distinct stages – **Vinayak Puja, Komali, Amanattam and Pusenkanattam**.

INDIAN PUPPETRY

SHADOW PUPPETS

India has a rich tradition in shadow puppetry, which has survived till now.
Some of the features of shadow puppetry are:



1 Shadow puppets are **flat figures cut out of leather** which has been treated to make it translucent.

2 The figures are **painted identically on both sides** of the leather.

3 The puppets are **placed on a white screen** with light falling from behind, creating a shadow on the screen.

4 The figures are manipulated so that the **silhouettes created on the blank screen** create telling imagery.

5 This tradition of shadow puppets survives in Orissa, Kerala, Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka, Maharashtra and Tamil Nadu.

POPULAR EXAMPLES OF
SHADOW PUPPETS

1 TOGALU GOMBAYATTA



- 1 It is the popular shadow theatre of **Karnataka**.
- 2 A unique feature of the Togalu Gombayetta puppets is the **variation of puppet size based on social status**, i.e. kings and religious figures are characterised by large puppets while common people and servants are shown by smaller puppets.

POPULAR EXAMPLES OF
SHADOW PUPPETS

2

RAVANCHHAYA



- 1 It is the **most exciting theatrical puppetry show** and is a popular form of entertainment in the **Odisha** region.

- 2 They are **not coloured**, hence throw **opaque shadows** on the screen.

- 3 The puppets are made of deer skin and depict bold, dramatic postures.

- 4 They **do not have any joints** attached to them, making it a **more complex** art.

- 5 There is **use of non-human puppets**, such as trees and animals as well.

- 6 The Ravanchhaya artists are thus **extremely trained** in their art – creating a lyrical and sensitive theatrical narration.

THOLU BOMMALATA



POPULAR EXAMPLES OF
SHADOW PUPPETS

3 THOLU BOMMALATA

Further Reference

THE HINDU, May 2018 : “Puppetry hangs
by a thread in Prakasam district”

- 1 It is the shadow theatre of Andhra Pradesh.
- 2 The show is accompanied by a classical background in the music and themed around mythological devotional tales of the epics and Puranas.
- 3 The puppets are larger in size and coloured on both sides.
- 4 They have jointed waist, shoulders, elbows and knees.

GLOVE PUPPETS



- 1 Glove puppets are also known as sleeve, hand or palm puppets.
- 2 They are small figures with head and arms wearing a long, flowing skirt as costume.
- 3 The puppets are generally made of cloth or wood, but some variations of paper puppet has also been seen.
- 4 These puppets are like limp dolls, but in the hands of an able puppeteer, are capable of producing a wide range of movements.

GLOVE PUPPETS

- 5 The puppeteer wears the puppet as glove, manipulating the head with his index finger.
- 6 The two hands are manipulated using the thumb and the middle finger – giving life and expression to the originally limp puppet.
- 7 The tradition of glove puppets in India is popular in Uttar Pradesh, Orissa, West Bengal and Kerala.
- 8 In Orissa, the puppeteer plays on the dholak with one hand and manipulates the puppet with the other.
- 9 In Uttar Pradesh, glove puppet plays usually present social themes, whereas in Orissa such plays are based on stories of Radha and Krishna.
- 10 The delivery of the dialogues, the movement of the puppet and the beat of the dholak are well synchronised and create a dramatic atmosphere.

INDIAN PUPPETRY

POPULAR EXAMPLE OF GLOVE PUPPETRY

1

PAVAKOOTHU



1 It is the traditional glove puppet show of Kerala.

2 It originated in the period around 18th century A.D.

3 The puppets are decorated with colourful headgears and face paints, which is evidence of a heavy influence of Kathakali dance form.

4 The musical instruments used during the performance are Chenda, Ilathalam and Shankha the conch.

5 The plays are themed around narrations of Ramayana and Mahabharata.



THOLPAVAKOOTHU IS DIFFERENT FROM PAVAKOOTHU

- *Tholpavakoothu is shadow puppet in Kerala whereas Pavakoothu is a form of glove puppet!*
- *The permanent stage in the temple courtyards of the temples (the only permanent traditional puppet theatres in India) is a three-sided enclosed structure called the koothu madam. The screen is lit by oil lamps made from halved coconuts.*



INDIAN PUPPETRY

ROD PUPPETS



- 1 Rod puppets are larger variations of glove puppet and are controlled by rods by the puppeteer from behind a screen.
- 2 It is mainly popular in the region of Eastern India.

INDIAN PUPPETRY

POPULAR EXAMPLES OF ROD PUPPETRY

1

PUTUL NACCH



1 It is the traditional rod puppet dance of **Bengal-Odisha-Assam** region.

2 The figures are generally **3-4ft. high** and dressed like characters of **Jatra**.

3 They generally have **three joints** – at the neck and at the shoulders.

4 The technique of manipulation is **interesting and highly theatrical**.

5 A **bamboo-made hub** is tied firmly to the **waist of the puppeteer** on which the rod holding the puppet is placed.

INDIAN PUPPETRY

POPULAR EXAMPLES OF ROD PUPPETRY

1

PUTUL NACCH



6

The puppeteers each holding one puppet, stand behind a head-high curtain and while manipulating the rods also move and dance imparting corresponding movements to the puppets.

7

While the puppeteers themselves sing and deliver the stylized prose dialogues, a group of musicians, usually three to four in numbers, sitting at the side of the stage provide the accompanying music with a drum, harmonium and cymbals.

8

The music and verbal text have close similarity with the Jatra theatre.

INDIAN PUPPETRY

POPULAR EXAMPLES OF ROD PUPPETRY

2

YAMPURI



1 It is the traditional rod puppet of Bihar.

2 They are carved out of a single piece of wood and then painted and dressed in bright colours.

3 Unlike the traditional Rod puppets of West Bengal and Orissa, these puppets are in one piece and have no joints.

4 As these puppets have no joints, the manipulation is different from other Rod puppets and requires greater dexterity.

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